



Historic repeat: By retaining the crown, NorthEast United became the first team since East Bengal's three-peat from 1989 to 1991 to defend the Durand Cup. DEBASISH BHADURI

HIGHLANDERS HIT THE HIGH NOTE WITH RECORD DURAND CUP TRIUMPH

A dominant NorthEast United beat Diamond Harbour 6-1 in the Durand Cup final, securing **back-to-back titles** in historic fashion at Salt Lake Stadium.

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A group of Assam Regiment soldiers broke into their famous marching song, "Badluram ka Badan," on the sidelines of the Salt Lake Stadium pitch, offering a melodious tribute to the champion of the 134th edition of the Durand Cup — NorthEast United FC. The performance engaged the small

band of Highlanders supporters who had come to cheer their side, even as organisers prepared the victory podium at the centre of the ground. Only minutes earlier, the Guwahati-based team had completed a thumping 6-1 victory over Kolkata debutant Diamond Harbour FC, setting the stage for a colourful prize-distribution ceremony

that felt like déjà vu for the NorthEast United fans. **Their side had, after all, retained the crown it had won in the previous edition, when it beat another Kolkata powerhouse, Mohun Bagan Super Giant.**

By pulling off this feat, NorthEast United matched the distinction of East Bengal, which was the last team to defend the Durand Cup, lifting it